

imports are important. You export what you are best at, where you have a competitive advantage, and you import what is good for your country.

In India's case, for example, you import certain ICT (information and communication technology) products, which are very important for our services exports.

**Q: If you take a look at the deals with the US and the EU, and earlier with the UK, do they fundamentally change the way we trade?**

**A:** I think it shows that India has emerged out of the shadows. Today, India is a very confident country. It engages with developed nations from a position of strength. Ultimately, free trade agreements are about the future. And as India lays out the road map to a \$30-trillion economy, the delta of opportunity is unparalleled. We have decisive leadership, with Prime Minister Modi leading from the front, willing to take risks, taking bold reform decisions, transforming the mindset of the nation. We have the demographic dividend.

20 | A country of 1.4 billion people, who are aspirational, connected through their smartphone to the rest of the world and desiring all the good things of life, is creating a huge demand that is unparalleled.

In every respect, India stands at the threshold of a rapid growth story, and when we engage with partners like the EU, UK, Switzerland, the US, Australia, New Zealand, and the Gulf countries, we are preparing ourselves to engage with the best in terms of quality, to leverage the strengths of our youth's talent and skills, and we are preparing our women to start contributing much more to the formal economy than in earlier years. In effect, we are making growth inclusive and sustainable.

**Q: What has changed that makes India confident that it can open its doors to other countries while also protect our industry?**

**A:** There's a fundamental mistake that the Congress and the UPA government under former Prime Minister Manmohan Singh made. They negotiated free trade deals or open borders with our competitors. They didn't have the courage of conviction to be able to talk to the developed world, other than Japan and South Korea. And sadly, both those deals are so badly negotiated that our exports to these two geographies have just not grown in the 15 years we had the FTA. In contrast, every one of the deals that PM Modi has concluded in the past three-and-a-half years is with



**“We have started preparing to work on the global stage, finding our position at the high table, rapidly growing the economy”**